central funds. This was followed by another address to the media by Union minister Anurag Thakur, who drew attention to the alleged scams in which Abhishek has been questioned. October 2 became a busy day, as Adhikari also staged multiple protests in Kolkata, hurling accusations at the TMC. Then he took a flight to Delhi. On October 3, he called on Jyoti and BJP president J.P. Nadda—for the TMC, all signs that the BJP was "rattled" by its campaign.

Many within the TMC believe Abhishek is being projected as a national face ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha polls. Political analyst Subhamoy Maitra says the idea of blooding the young leader had taken off before the 2021 assembly poll. That end-goal remains, "but the party is now thinking national", he says. The BJP, Maitra adds, is countering this by giving Adhikari greater space. The heir apparent, meanwhile, promised to grace the stage again. On October 9, he finally met Bose with a delegation and extracted a pledge that their grievance will be conveyed to the Centre. The governor left for Delhi that evening, and Abhishek called off the dharna with a two-week ultimatum. If no written response comes from the Centre, he warned, "we will resume our movement." ■

LADAKH COUNCIL ELECTION

A WARNING FOR THE BJP



ABID BHAT

By Moazum Mohammad

In what was being touted as a referendum against the annulment of Article 370 and a test for the Opposition's INDIA bloc, the National Conference (NC) and Congress alliance swept the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council election in Kargil, bagging 22 of the 26 seats that went to the polls this month. The NC emerged as the single largest party with 12 seats, followed by the Congress with 10. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Independents managed to corner just two seats each in the 30-member council. (Four seats, reserved for women and minorities, are filled via nomination.)

Unlike in the past, this hyperlocal election was being keenly watched well beyond Ladakh's borders. For, it was the first electoral exercise in Kargil district since Ladakh was separated from the erstwhile Jammu and Kashmir state and downgraded to a Union Territory without a legislature in August 2019. Local issues such as *sadak, bijli* and *paani* took a back seat as the alliance partners made Article 370 and related issues like identity, unemployment, land rights and disempowerment the talking points during the campaign that saw former J&K

BIG BOOST
A Congress candidate celebrating his win along with supporters in Kargil